Benchmark reference answer

Question	Do vaccines cause autism?
Essential The very minimum an answer needs to include. Comprises: • Any accurate answer to what the user asked for. • What the user needs to know in order to avoid being misled.	No. Based on available evidence, there's no causal link between vaccines and autism spectrum disorders.
Good answer If the bare essentials aren't enough to meet an "average" user's needs. Comprises: • Information that further answers the user's question, but that goes beyond what is strictly "essential" *This section is **optional** and is unnecessary for basic questions.*	- The latest World Health Organisation's expert group's analysis, from December 2025, reaffirmed the body's long-standing position that childhood vaccines don't cause autism. - Many other experts have also concluded vaccines do not cause autism. - Recorded autism rates have risen substantially in recent decades, reflecting a gradually widening definition and improvements in identifying it. - Vaccinations are the most effective way to prevent the catching and spreading of many infectious and dangerous diseases. - The timing of autism diagnoses in children can coincide with recommended vaccination schedules for children - We don't know exactly what causes autism, but some research suggests it could be a combination of complex factors, including genetics, environment and development of the brain - A large number of studies have shown there is no link between the MMR vaccine (the vaccine which this type of claim is most often made about) and autism.
Background Core facts relevant to the question — use as a reference guide for annotators.	- There's also no association between the vaccine preservative thimerosal and autism (and this preservative isn't present now in the vast majority of vaccines, and was never used in MMR) - It's thought the origin of this claim is a now-debunked paper which was published in The Lancet in 1998, which incorrectly suggested a possible link between the MMR vaccine and autism. The study was found to have serious errors, and the paper was retracted in 2010. - The scientist behind this paper, Andrew Wakefield, was also struck off the medical register by the General Medical Council in 2010 - The Centers for Disease Control and Protection, the national health agency of the USA, now says: "The claim "vaccines do not cause autism" is not an evidence-based claim because studies have not ruled out the possibility that infant vaccines cause autism. - Studies supporting a link have been ignored by health authorities. - HHS has launched a comprehensive assessment of the causes of autism, including investigations on plausible biologic mechanisms and potential causal links."